through Bihar would have taken a somewhat northerly route through Patna in order to accommodate the imperial capital.

The Dakshina Path also remained an important highway, especially given the extensive Mauryan conquests in the south. However, it appears that the trajectory of the road had shifted somewhat eastwards since the Iron Age. The new route passed through Vidisha and then made its way to Pratishthana (modern Paithan in Aurangabad district of Maharashtra). It is likely that. by the Mauryan period, a branch of the southern highway already connected Ujjain to the ports of Gujarat although this route would become more important during the Gupta period.

Meanwhile, the sea routes were gaining in importance. We know that, by Mauryan times, there was coastal shipping between Tamralipti in Bengal and Sri Lanka. Links with South East Asia were also being established. It is likely that the ships initially hugged the coast but, as we will discuss in the next chapter, nautical skills and shipbuilding technology were soon advanced enough to allow merchants to directly cross the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal.

A SENSE OF HISTORY

By the time the Mauryans created their empire, Indian civilization was already well developed and conscious of itself. It also had a developed sense of history as evidenced by the long lists of kings preserved in the Puranas and elsewhere (this is a comment about their intent, not necessarily their accuracy). The Mauryan empire was drawn from this preexisting milieu and used its symbols—including the idea of the Chakravartin or Universal Monarch. However, the Mauryans introduced an important innovation—the use of columns and rock inscriptions to record their presence. As already discussed, these were meant to mark territory and impress the subjects but, I suspect, they were also meant to speak to us. Like monarchs around the world, Ashoka wanted to be remembered. He wanted future generations to be impressed by his power and to think well of him.